

Data Privacy Check

How much of your data is actually out there

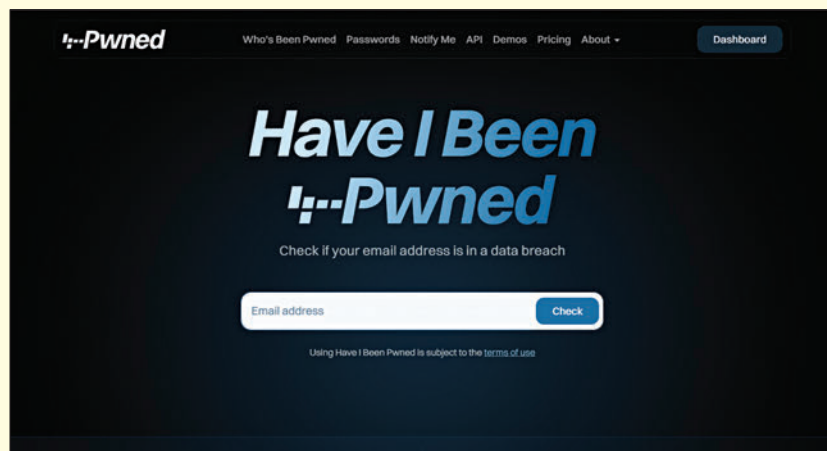
What you can really do about it

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A viral thread on X this month promised to delete “99.8% of your online presence” in a few steps. That number isn’t measurable and nobody’s claiming it with evidence behind it. But the underlying advice is

Use Google’s actual removal tool

Google’s current tool for this is called Results About You, found in your Google account or at goo.gle/result-aboutyou. It scans search results for your phone number, email or address



sound, it’s just worth knowing what each step actually accomplishes and what it doesn’t.

Opt out of data brokers

Sites like Spokeo, Whitepages and BeenVerified scrape public records and sell your name, address and phone number to anyone who searches. Each one has an opt out page, usually buried in the footer. Search yourself on each, find your listing, submit the removal request. It takes about ten minutes across all three and it’s worth doing, though these sites tend to relist scraped data over time, so this isn’t a one time job.

and lets you request removal in a few taps. Here’s the part that tends to get glossed over, it removes the result from Google Search, it does not delete the page or the data from the website hosting it. If a data broker’s page is still live, it can resurface later or show up on Bing or any of the other search engines. Pair this step with the broker opt outs above, don’t treat it as a replacement for them.

Find the accounts you forgot existed

Search your Gmail for “verify your email” or “welcome to.” Every result is a signup you made and forgot about.

Log into each, find account deletion in settings, and close what you don’t use. Tedious, but it’s the only way to actually shrink your footprint rather than just hiding it from search.

Check what’s already leaked

Head to haveibeenpwned.com and enter your email. It’s a legitimate, widely used breach database, not a sketchy tool. It’ll show you which breaches your email showed up in. Change any password that was exposed, and if you’ve reused that password anywhere else, change it in those places as well to stay safe.

Lock down Google’s tracking

In My Activity, you can delete your history and switch Web and App Activity, Location History and YouTube History to off. This stops future collection, it doesn’t erase whatever third parties have already inferred from your years of past activity.

Old posts, with a real caveat

Reddit’s Redact tool overwrites comments before deleting, which is meaningfully better than a straight delete since it beats basic archival scraping. For X, free tools like TweetDelete only reach your most recent roughly 3,200 tweets, that’s a platform API limit, not a tool limitation, so older history usually needs a paid tier or an archive upload. Don’t take a free tool’s marketing at face value here.

Reduce future exposure

Use alias email services like SimpleLogin for new signups, so a single leak doesn’t expose your real inbox. Switching to a tracker blocking browser like Firefox or Brave helps going forward, it does nothing for data already collected.

The real takeaway, none of this is a delete button. It’s maintenance, and it works best done twice a year. 